

Blocks for Artists: Opportunities and Constraints in a Minecraft Virtual Exhibition

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Abstract

As virtual platforms redefine the landscape of creative exhibition, *Minecraft* emerges as a uniquely flexible yet constrained medium for curating digital art. This study presents a stakeholder-centered thematic analysis of a university-hosted virtual art exhibition built within *Minecraft*. Through interviews with artists, student organizers, and institutional staff, we examine how the platform's aesthetic limitations, social affordances, and technical demands influence artistic workflows and event legitimacy. Findings reveal tensions between creative freedom and block-based constraints, the hybrid social dynamics of virtual and physical engagement, and institutional narratives that frame *Minecraft* both as playful novelty and outreach innovation. This research opens a discussion about future human-computer interaction practices in virtual curatorial environments, particularly within educational and artistic domains and requirements for such environments.

CCS Concepts

• Human-centered computing → Empirical studies in HCI.

Keywords

Empirical Study, Virtual Exhibition, Human-Computer Interaction

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1 Introduction

As educational institutions and cultural organizations seek novel ways to engage global audiences, virtual exhibitions in game environments have emerged as a promising avenue for widening participation and experimentation. *Minecraft* offers unparalleled freedom for constructing custom exhibition spaces, yet its intrinsic voxel aesthetic and platform architecture introduce unique curatorial, technical, and institutional challenges. While prior research has explored *Minecraft*'s use in learning contexts and simple collaborative builds,

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Figure 1: University buildings recreated in *Minecraft* as a venue for a virtual exhibition [2].



Figure 2: View inside the building, showing some of the works presented [1].

little work integrates the voices of creators, organizers, and administrators to reveal how these stakeholders collectively shape a virtual art exhibition. This research contributes a stakeholder-centered thematic analysis that illuminates key dynamics of *Minecraft* exhibitions. This inquiry can serve as a foundation for further studies concerning virtual exhibitions and forming requirements for such projects.

2 Related Work

The use of *Minecraft* as a platform for creative expression and education has been increasingly explored in recent years. The game has been framed [8] not only as a game but as a flexible medium balancing creativity and structured challenge, setting a foundation for its use in digital art and education. Building on this, several studies have highlighted *Minecraft*'s educational benefits, emphasizing its capacity to foster learning and social engagement [6][3]. Case studies [7] demonstrate its practical application in facilitating creative dialogue and collaboration.

Emerging research extends *Minecraft*'s role into the realm of virtual art and exhibition experiences. Other previous studies [15][11] signal expansion of *Minecraft* and similar virtual environments into immersive artistic spaces. This is complemented by studies on digital art exhibitions more broadly [14][13] offering practitioner-focused insights into engagement and satisfaction.

User-centric perspectives have also been captured [9]. Broader cultural and technological reflections on digital art during transformative periods have been studied [5]. Other studies [10][4] shed light on the evolving practices and challenges faced by curators in virtual settings.

Critical questions about the nature of art and audience engagement in immersive digital environments have also been raised [12], situating the current study within ongoing debates about virtuality, embodiment, and artistic experience.

3 Methodology

An exploratory approach guided this study. We recruited eight participants via purposive and snowball sampling to represent three stakeholder groups: three practicing artists, three student organizers, and two university staff members overseeing institutional support. Each participant engaged in an unstructured video interview lasting twenty to forty-five minutes, which included a live walkthrough of the *Minecraft* exhibition environment. Recordings were transcribed verbatim. Analysis followed Braun and Clarke's six-phase thematic framework—familiarization, coding, theme development, review, definition, and reporting—with two researchers independently coding transcripts and reconciling discrepancies to ensure analytical rigor.

3.1 The Exhibition Context

The study was situated within a virtual art exhibition hosted in *Minecraft*, a platform chosen for its creative flexibility and widespread familiarity. The virtual exhibition space was a digital recreation of the rooms and surroundings of the University (Fig. 1), a historically significant site that provided a recognizable and context-rich setting for the project. This approach grounded the virtual experience in a familiar architectural context. The space included rooms reflecting real-world counterparts (Fig. 2), including a dedicated room for post-digital graphics course students.

4 Findings

Our thematic analysis surfaced four overarching themes that capture the multifaceted dynamics of hosting a virtual art exhibition in *Minecraft*:

Affordances and Aesthetic Constraints

Participants celebrated *Minecraft*'s "infinite sandbox" for rapid prototyping and collaborative building but noted that the block-based medium flattened nuanced textures and fine details. Many emphasized the importance of controlling work size, with some preferring to specify exact dimensions, while others deferred to curatorial judgment, trusting that their works would be appropriately scaled. Some noted the difficulty in accurately representing real-world proportions and the need to adapt their designs to fit

Hybrid Social Dynamics

The virtual exhibition extended reach beyond the campus community, inviting remote visitors who could not attend in person. Yet all stakeholder groups agreed that *Minecraft* could not fully replicate the spontaneous, serendipitous encounters central to physical exhibition openings. A crucial facet, as expressed by some participants, was the virtual environment of the exhibition - a recreation of the university. This was used by the university as an outside advertisement, particularly during recruitment of new students. Some participants even expressed in the interviews that this was the main selling point of the exhibition, not the images inside of the buildings. Participants recommended pairing physical on-site events with scheduled in-game walkthroughs to balance accessibility with face-to-face networking.

Technical and Accessibility Challenges

Server stability emerged as a constant concern. Hosting costs and technical management drew organizers away from creative tasks. Some participants described initial uncertainty about how the virtual space would function, with expectations of technical glitches or visual distortions.

Institutional Framing and Legitimacy

University staff expressed mixed attitudes: some saw the *Minecraft* format as an innovative outreach tool, while others viewed it as a leisure activity unfit for formal exhibition. The exhibition was framed as both a continuation and departure from conventional shows, though some deemed it weaker than physical galleries and noted virtual exhibitions' lack of novelty reduced its perceived innovation. This was not a unanimous voice as some participants still perceived the virtual exhibition as innovative, particularly within the local community.

5 Discussion and Contribution

By centering creators, student organizers, and institutional actors, this study offers a comprehensive thematic analysis of a *Minecraft* virtual art exhibition. It is evident that technical affordances and constraints shape artistic workflows, hybrid event models balance global inclusion with interpersonal richness, and strategic institutional framing can legitimize game-based cultural events. The key contribution of this inquiry is its stakeholder-centered framework, which both advances scholarly discourse in HCI and digital art and provides practical foundations for designing and implementing future virtual exhibitions in game environments.

6 Conclusions and Future Work

This research contributes a multi-stakeholder perspective on *Minecraft*-based exhibitions, revealing concerns of several groups of users. The opportunities and constraints presented are a promising look into the possibilities of virtual exhibitions in this medium and offer

a starting point for requirement engineering for this application. Limitations include a single-institution sample and omission of visitor perspectives. Future research should integrate direct audience feedback through usability studies, conduct longitudinal, cross-platform comparisons (e.g., VR, MR, alternate game engines), and involve end users in participatory design to refine exhibition tools and social features.

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